

83 Jehoshaphat

A godly king who taught his people God's law, prayed his way out of disaster, and kept making friends with the wrong family.

Jehoshaphat, son of Asa, was one of Judah's best kings. He sought God, sent teachers across the land with the book of the law, and reformed the courts. When a vast army invaded, he admitted he did not know what to do and turned to God in prayer, and Judah won without striking a blow. Yet he tied his family to Ahab's by marriage, fought beside Ahab, and later partnered with Ahab's sons. A prophet asked him, "Shouldest thou help the ungodly?" His story shows real faith beside a real weakness, and how alliances shape later generations.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yehoshafat</i> , "the LORD has judged"
Family	Son of Asa and Azubah; father of Jehoram (1 Kings 22:42, 50)
Crowned	Age 35 (1 Kings 22:42)
Reign	25 years, c. 872–848 BC, first as co-regent with Asa
Key places	Jerusalem, Ramoth-gilead, En-gedi, Berachah, Ezion-geber
Key people	Ahab, Micaiah, Jehu son of Hanani, Jahaziel, Elisha
New Testament	Named as "Josaphat" in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:8)

"O our God, wilt thou not judge them? for we have no might against this great company that cometh against us; neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee."

2 Chronicles 20:12, KJV

The life of Jehoshaphat

Dates are approximate (BC). He probably reigned with his sick father Asa from c. 872 BC, alone from c. 870 BC.

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| c. 872–870 BC | ● Becomes king |
| Age 35 | He begins to reign in the fourth year of Ahab of Israel. He walks in the first ways of David, seeks God rather than the Baals, and strengthens Judah against Israel. <i>1 Kings 22:41–43; 2 Chronicles 17:1–6</i> |
| 3rd year of his reign | ● Sends out teachers |
| | He sends princes, Levites and priests through the cities of Judah, carrying the book of the law of the LORD and teaching the people. <i>2 Chronicles 17:7–9</i> |
| Early reign | ● Alliance with Ahab |
| | Rich and honoured, he joins himself to Ahab by marriage. His son Jehoram marries Ahab's daughter, a match that will bring Baal worship into Judah's royal house. <i>2 Chronicles 18:1; 2 Kings 8:18</i> |
| c. 853 BC | ● Ramoth-gilead |
| | He joins Ahab against Syria. Syrian captains mistake him for Ahab; he cries out, and God turns them away. <i>1 Kings 22:1–38; 2 Chronicles 18:1–34</i> |
| After the battle | ● Rebuked, then reforms |
| | Jehu son of Hanani rebukes him for helping the ungodly. Jehoshaphat goes out among the people to bring them back to God and sets judges in every fortified city. <i>2 Chronicles 19:1–11</i> |
| Later | ● Victory without a battle |
| | Moab, Ammon and men of Mount Seir invade. He proclaims a fast and prays with all Judah. Singers lead the army out, and the invaders destroy one another. <i>2 Chronicles 20:1–30</i> |
| c. 848 BC | ● Dies |
| | After twenty-five years as king he is buried with his fathers in the city of David. His son Jehoram reigns in his place. <i>1 Kings 22:50; 2 Chronicles 21:1</i> |

Key activities

Kings says the high places were not taken away (1 Kings 22:43), while Chronicles says he removed them (2 Chronicles 17:6), then also notes they remained (2 Chronicles 20:33). Many readers think he removed some, or removed pagan shrines while others survived.

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- 1 Taught the law.** He sent officials and Levites through Judah to teach from the book of the law. *2 Chronicles 17:7-9*

 - 2 Made a risky alliance.** He told Ahab, "I am as thou art, and my people as thy people." *1 Kings 22:4; 2 Chronicles 18:3*

 - 3 Asked for a true prophet.** After about four hundred prophets all promised victory, he asked, "Is there not here a prophet of the LORD besides?" *1 Kings 22:5-8*

 - 4 Took correction.** After Jehu's rebuke he went out himself, from Beersheba to Mount Ephraim, to bring the people back to God. *2 Chronicles 19:1-4*

 - 5 Reformed justice.** He told the judges, "ye judge not for man, but for the LORD," and warned them against bribes. *2 Chronicles 19:5-11*

 - 6 Prayed in helplessness.** Facing invasion, he stood in the temple and admitted, "neither know we what to do." *2 Chronicles 20:3-13*

 - 7 Sent singers ahead.** He appointed singers to go before the army, praising God's mercy. *2 Chronicles 20:20-22*

 - 8 Built ships that broke.** He joined Ahaziah of Israel in a shipping venture. A prophet warned him, and the ships were wrecked. *2 Chronicles 20:35-37; 1 Kings 22:48-49*

 - 9 Marched against Moab.** He joined Joram of Israel and the king of Edom. Elisha helped them only for Jehoshaphat's sake. *2 Kings 3:4-27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jehoshaphat.

Old Testament

1 Kings 22:41–50; 2 Chronicles 17–20	The two main accounts
1 Kings 22:43	He walked in the ways of Asa his father
2 Chronicles 19:2	"Shouldest thou help the ungodly?"
2 Kings 3:14	Elisha heeds Joram only for Jehoshaphat's sake
2 Chronicles 21:12	Elijah rebukes Jehoram for leaving his father's ways
Echo: 1 Samuel 17:47	"The battle is the LORD's," as at 2 Chronicles 20:15

New Testament

Matthew 1:8	"Josaphat" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Corinthians 6:14	"Be ye not unequally yoked together"
Echo: Acts 16:25–26	Paul and Silas sing in prison

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did Jehoshaphat admit in his prayer (2 Chronicles 20:12)?
2. *Understand:* Jehoshaphat was a godly king, yet he kept joining himself to Ahab's family. Why might a good person keep making the same mistake?
3. *Apply:* "Neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee." Where do you need to pray that prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* Jehoshaphat's alliances affected his children and grandchildren. What partnership or friendship in your life needs a hard look?